



THE MORNING KICKOFF

📍 FIFA World Cup 26 — United States · Canada · Mexico · The final is set: Spain–Argentina at MetLife on Sunday

📌 England 1–2 Argentina — Messi's two late assists flip the semi in four minutes

📅 Sunday's final: Spain–Argentina, 21:00 our time — third place France–England Saturday

★ Crystal Ball: England 2–1 missed — both semi calls fell. Record now 5 from 9

🔥 SEMI-FINAL 2 · ENGLAND 1–2 ARGENTINA

TWO ASSISTS FROM ETERNITY.

For half an hour, England were headed to MetLife: Anthony Gordon tapped in Morgan Rogers' cross in the 55th and Pickford was repelling everything. Then Messi took over. Enzo Fernández equalised from distance in the 85th, and two minutes into stoppage time Lautaro Martínez headed Messi's cross in at the back post. The champions live on — and Sunday's final is the one the whole tournament pointed to: Spain against Argentina.



Lionel Messi — no goal, both assists. At 39, one game from back-to-back World Cups.

ALSO THIS MORNING

- ★ The Crystal Ball called England 2–1; Argentina answered with two goals in the last five minutes plus stoppage. Both semi calls missed — the record drops to 5 from 9.
- ⚡ The early money makes Spain clear final favourites: 42 against Argentina's 27 on Kalshi, with a big 33 on the draw. Half a million dollars traded already.
- 📅 Rest days today and tomorrow. Saturday: France–England for third place in Miami, 23:00 our time — and the Golden Boot may be settled there. Sunday: the final, 21:00.

INSIDE TODAY'S EDITION

- P.2 England 1–2 Argentina — the full report: Gordon, Enzo, and Lautaro's stoppage-time winner
- P.3 The final weekend previewed: France–England Saturday, Spain–Argentina Sunday
- P.4 Golden Boot: Messi and Mbappé still locked on 8 — one final each to settle it
- P.5 The road ends here: the bracket complete, the week to the trophy

THE FINAL WEEKEND (CENTRAL EUROPE)

France
–
England



Sat
23:00



Spain –
Argentina



Sun
21:00

FULL
PREVIEWS →
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THE MORNING
KICKOFF

Thursday 16 July 2026 · Edition #11 · Results & stats: FIFA, ESPN, FOX Sports, NBC Sports, Yahoo Sports — checked morning of 16 July 2026. Market prices: Kalshi, morning of 16 July. Kick-off times in Central European Time unless flagged otherwise.

⚡ LATE DRAMA

📍 Mercedes-Benz Stadium, Atlanta



England

1 – 2

FULL TIME

Argentina



⚽ **Gordon** 55' · from Rogers' cross

⚽ **Enzo Fernández** 85' · long-range strike

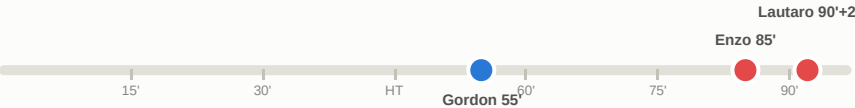
⚽ **Lautaro Martínez** 90'+2 · header · Messi cross

This fixture never does mercy. England played the disciplined, patient game Tuchel promised, and when Morgan Rogers' curling cross found Anthony Gordon at the far post in the 55th, Atlanta's away end believed. Pickford — twice from Álvarez, once from a Nicolás González header — kept the lead alive as Argentina's pressure built and the fouls piled up in a fractious, stop-start contest.

Then, as he has for twenty years, Messi decided otherwise. In the 85th he slipped the pass that Enzo Fernández hammered home from range. Two minutes into stoppage time his cross found Lautaro Martínez at the back post, and the header ended it. England's first defeat of the tournament came five minutes from a first final since 1966; the champions march on to face Spain — the final everyone wanted.

MATCH TIMELINE

● Argentina above · ● England below



★ STAR OF THE MATCH

Lionel Messi

Quiet for eighty minutes, decisive in the ten that mattered: two assists, one final. At 39, he is one win from becoming the first back-to-back champion since Brazil in 1962.



Lautaro Martínez

The extra-time winner against Switzerland, now the stoppage-time header that broke England. Argentina's closer keeps arriving exactly on time.

⚡ England led from the 55th to the 85th — five minutes from MetLife when Enzo Fernández struck from outside the box

⚽ Messi finished with no goal but both assists, the second a right-footed cross Lautaro headed in at the back post in the 92nd

👁 Pickford denied Álvarez twice and tipped over a González header — a scrappy game with 19 first-half fouls brought only two yellows

➔ **WHAT IT MEANS** Sunday at MetLife: Spain–Argentina, the tournament's two best sides, 21:00 our time. England drop to Saturday's third-place match against France in Miami.

THIRD PLACE · SATURDAY · MIAMI



Sat 23:00
 Kick-off 5:00 PM ET at the stadium Hard Rock Stadium, Miami

- The game neither wanted, carrying the prize both strikers do: the Golden Boot. Mbappé (8) needs one goal to break his tie with Messi — who plays a day later. Kane (5) and Bellingham (4) get one last swing; so does Dembélé (5). The early market makes France heavy favourites at 50%, with England and the draw level on 26 — heavy legs and heavier hearts after Atlanta.
- ⦿ **Mbappé one goal from the outright Golden Boot lead — with Messi watching from the final**
 - ⦿ **How England respond four days after losing a final spot in the 92nd minute**
 - ⦿ **Expect rotation everywhere — third-place games are historically the tournament's most open**



KEY MAN · FRANCE
Kylian Mbappé

Blanked by Spain, stuck on 8, and handed one more game. A goal in Miami and the Golden Boot is effectively his — unless Messi answers at MetLife on Sunday.

THE FINAL · SUNDAY · METLIFE



Sun 21:00
 Kick-off 3:00 PM ET at the stadium MetLife Stadium, New York / New Jersey

- The two best teams of the tournament, and it isn't close: Spain's record wall against the champions who refuse to die. Spain have conceded twice all tournament; Argentina have won their last three knockouts after trailing or level in the closing stages. Yamal against Messi — the heir against the throne. The early money leans Spanish: 42 to 27, with a third of it on the draw. The Crystal Ball returns Sunday morning with the full call.
- ⦿ **Yamal v Messi — the 18-year-old face of the next decade against the 39-year-old face of the last two**
 - ⦿ **Argentina's late-game sorcery against a Spain side that simply never trails**
 - ⦿ **Oyarzabal (5 goals) quietly two behind the Boot leaders — and he plays the biggest stage of all**



KEY MAN · SPAIN
Lamine Yamal

A penalty won against France, a semi-final owned, and now the stage every 18-year-old dreams of. Beat Argentina and the torch isn't passed — it's taken.

HOW THE FINALISTS GOT HERE

The knockout runs that built Sunday's final

TOMORROW: FINAL COUNTDOWN — THEN THE THIRD-PLACE CRYSTAL BALL SATURDAY, THE FINAL SUNDAY



Lionel Messi

Two assists in Atlanta — plays the final Sunday

8



Kylian Mbappé

One last game: third place Saturday, one goal for the lead

8



Erling Haaland

Eliminated — his race ended one goal short

7

1	Lionel Messi Argentina · the final Sun	8
2	Kylian Mbappé France · third place Sat	8
3	Erling Haaland Norway · eliminated	7
4	Harry Kane England · third place Sat	5
5	Ousmane Dembélé France · third place Sat	5
6	Mikel Oyarzabal Spain · the final Sun	5
7	Jude Bellingham England · third place Sat	4

Tie-break: assists, then minutes played. Messi's two assists last night strengthen his tie-break — but Mbappé plays first, on Saturday in Miami.

⚡ NUMBERS OF THE DAY

90'+2

The minute Lautaro's header won it — two minutes into stoppage time, five from penalties

2

Messi assists in the final ten minutes plus stoppage — no goal required

1962

The last back-to-back champions were Brazil — Argentina are one win from joining them

\$509k

Already traded on Sunday's final on Kalshi — Spain open as clear favourites



KNOCKOUT BRACKET

Quarter-finals 9-12 July · Semi-finals 14-15 July

QUARTER-FINALS

QF1 · FT · France won 2-0 · · Boston

France

Morocco

QF2 · FT · Spain won 2-1 · · Los Angeles

Spain

Belgium

QF3 · FT · England won 2-1 aet · · Miami

Norway

England

QF4 · FT · Argentina won 3-1 aet · · Kansas City

Argentina

Switzerland

SEMI-FINALS

FT · Spain won 2-0 · Dallas
France 0-2 Spain

FT · Argentina won 2-1 · Atlanta
England 1-2 Argentina

THE FINAL

Sunday 19 July · 21:00 ·
Spain v Argentina

MetLife Stadium, New York / New Jersey

YOUR WEEK IN FOOTBALL

Wednesday 15 July — the trophy on Sunday 19 July

WED
15 Jul

SF2: England 1-2
Argentina

THU
16 Jul

Rest day

FRI
17 Jul

Rest day

SAT
18 Jul

Third place:
France-England ·
23:00

SUN
19 Jul

THE FINAL:
Spain-Argentina ·
21:00

MON
20 Jul

The wrap-up
special

TUE
21 Jul

Football-free
mornings resume



See you tomorrow morning.

Next edition: the countdown to MetLife — final build-up, team news from both camps, and fresh market prices.